CENTRE FOR FILM AND MEDIA STUDIES COURSE ESSAY COVER SHEET

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Afro-Pessimism and Speculative Fiction in *Get Out* (2017)

Horror is an inherently potent genre for dramatizing contemporary social issues. Horror films have an ability to build our deepest fears into exaggerated monsters onto which we can project our hidden fears. However, some films do not play into this trope of monster versus victim and instead show you exactly what you fear without any exaggeration, and Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) is one of them. This essay reads the film through Afro-Pessimism and speculative fiction and argues that the scene in which Chris is mentally prepared for the Coagula is the best place in the film to see how the two work together. To do that, this essay will use the concepts of colour-blind racism and racialized social systems, alongside the Afro-Pessimist ideas of commodification and social death, to analyse the scene.

Get Out follows Chris, a young Black photographer, who visits the family of his white girlfriend, Rose, for the first time. Although Rose's family, the Armitages, seem liberal and accepting of their interracial relationship, their constant comments about race make Chris uncomfortable. During the visit, Rose's mother, Missy, secretly hypnotises Chris under the guise of helping him quit smoking. As the weekend progresses, Chris realises that the Armitages and their guests view Black people as objects rather than individuals. He eventually discovers a horrifying scheme in which wealthy white people bid on Black bodies and transfer their own consciousness into them through a procedure called the Coagula. By the time Chris decides to leave, it is too late. Rose reveals that she has been part of the plan all along, and Chris is captured and prepared for the operation, forcing him to fight for his survival.

It is difficult to fully understand the concerns explored in *Get Out* without considering the history from which they emerge. The United States was built on the institution of slavery, a system that reduced Black people to property and positioned them as objects to be owned, controlled and exploited. While slavery was formally abolished in 1865 and legal segregation eventually dismantled through the Civil Rights Movement, the end of these systems did not bring an end to racial inequality (Bonilla-Silva, 2015:1362). The social, political and economic structures shaped by slavery continued to influence American society long after their official abolition. For many Black Americans, the legacy of slavery remains visible through persistent inequalities in education, wealth, housing, employment and criminal justice (Bonilla-Silva, 2015:1362-1363).

This historical context becomes particularly important when considering the period in which *Get Out* was released. The film appeared shortly after the presidency of Barack Obama, a period during which many commentators claimed that the United States had entered a post-racial era. The election of America's first Black president was often presented as evidence that the country had overcome its racist past (Poll, 2018:71). However, the continued existence of racial inequality suggested otherwise. Peele's film directly challenges the assumption that racism belongs to the past. Rather than focusing on overt racial hatred, *Get Out* examines the subtle and often hidden forms of anti-Blackness that continue to structure social relations in the present (Mollenthiel, 2023:219).

In the present, racism often operates differently from the overt forms associated with slavery, segregation and Jim Crow. Rather than being expressed through explicit declarations of racial superiority, it frequently appears in subtle and indirect ways that are more difficult to identify and challenge (Combs, 2018:39). Bonilla-Silva (2015:1364) argues that this shift has produced what he terms colour-blind racism, a form of racism that relies on the belief that race no longer matters and that society has moved beyond racial discrimination. Within this framework, persistent racial inequalities are interpreted as the result of individual choices, cultural differences or personal shortcomings rather than the outcome of long-standing structural inequalities. Bonilla-Silva (2015:1360-1361) contends that beneath these claims of racial progress lies what he calls a racialized social system, in which racial hierarchies continue to shape access to opportunities, resources and social power. As a result, contemporary racism often manifests not through open hostility but through forms of liberalism that proclaim equality while leaving the structures that produce racial inequality largely intact. It is within the existence of these kind of systems that the ideas of Afro-Pessimism are founded.

Afro-Pessimism is a theoretical framework that examines the enduring relationship between Blackness and oppression in the modern world. Unlike approaches that understand racism as a social problem that can gradually be overcome through education, legal reform or political progress, Afro-Pessimism argues that anti-Blackness is deeply embedded within the foundations of modern society itself (Poll, 2018:70). Central to this perspective is the argument that the modern

world was structured through systems such as slavery and colonialism, which positioned Black people as socially excluded and vulnerable subjects. As a result, the effects of slavery are understood not as a historical phenomenon that ended with abolition, but as an ongoing condition that continues to shape social, political and economic life (Jenkins, 2024:44). Afro-Pessimist scholars therefore question the extent to which Black people can ever achieve full inclusion within a society whose institutions were historically built upon their exclusion.

Speculative fiction provides a useful means of exploring these concerns because it allows writers and filmmakers to imagine alternative realities, technologies and social conditions while remaining engaged with real-world issues. Rather than functioning simply as escapist fantasy, speculative fiction often exaggerates, reimagines or transforms existing social relations in order to reveal truths that may be difficult to observe in everyday life. By presenting hypothetical scenarios, speculative fiction creates a space in which complex questions about power, identity, inequality and social structures can be explored from new perspectives. In this sense, speculative fiction is not concerned with predicting the future as much as it is concerned with using imagination to illuminate realities of the present (Jenkins, 2024:43).

The chosen scene serves as a useful site through which these concepts can be examined in practice. Situated near the climax of the film, the sequence in which Jim Hudson explains the Coagula procedure condenses many of the film's central themes into a single interaction. Here, issues of anti-Blackness, possession, captivity, commodification and social death become explicit, while the speculative elements of the narrative provide a framework through which these concerns can be explored.

The first aspect of the scene that reflects both Afro-Pessimist concerns and Bonilla-Silva's critique of contemporary racism is the character of Jim Hudson. Earlier in the film, Jim appears markedly different from the other white guests at the Armitage estate. Unlike those who openly comment on Chris's body, physical abilities and Blackness, Jim presents himself as thoughtful, self-aware and sympathetic. He even appears uncomfortable with the behaviour of the other guests (Poll, 2018:86). However, this perception is dismantled during the Coagula explanation scene. When

Chris asks why Black people are being targeted, Jim quickly distances himself from any suggestion of racism, insisting that he does not care about Chris's race and that what he wants is Chris's eye.

In many ways, Jim embodies Bonilla-Silva's (2015:1365) concept of colour-blind racism. He does not view himself as racist because he does not express overt hatred towards Black people, yet he remains willing to participate in a system that strips Chris of his humanity, agency and bodily autonomy. What makes Jim particularly unsettling is that he genuinely believes he is innocent (Mollenthiel, 2023:218). His actions reveal the limitations of liberalism that proclaims equality while remaining invested in structures that continue to privilege whiteness. Through Jim, the film suggests that contemporary racism is often maintained not by people who openly embrace racist beliefs, but by those who convince themselves that they have moved beyond race while continuing to benefit from racial inequality.

The scene also reveals the operation of what Bonilla-Silva describes as a racialized social system. Importantly, Chris's exploitation is not the result of a single racist individual but an entire network of people working together. The Armitage family, the guests at the party and Jim Hudson all play different roles in the same process. Together they create a system in which Black bodies are identified, desired, purchased and controlled (Mollenthiel, 2023:218). This is significant because it shifts attention away from individual prejudice and toward structure. The horror of the scene lies not only in what Jim plans to do, but in the fact that everyone around him accepts it as normal. The Coagula is treated as a legitimate procedure rather than a violent act. In this way, the film mirrors the way racial systems often function in reality, where inequality is maintained through institutions and collective practices rather than the actions of a few openly racist individuals (Combs, 2018:42).

The speculative nature of the Coagula procedure plays an important role in exposing these systems. On a literal level, the transplantation of consciousness is impossible. However, speculative fiction is not concerned with realism; it uses imagination to reveal aspects of reality that might otherwise remain hidden. By imagining a world where wealthy white people can literally occupy Black bodies, Peele transforms historical patterns of racial exploitation into a visible and horrifying reality (Mollenthiel, 2023:219). The procedure exaggerates the logic of slavery and anti-Blackness

without fundamentally changing it (Jenkins, 2024:47-49). Historically, Black people were reduced to property whose bodies and labour could be used for the benefit of others. Through the Coagula, that same relationship is reimagined in a contemporary setting. The speculative dimension of the film therefore strengthens its Afro-Pessimist concerns by demonstrating how old structures can survive within new forms.

Another important element of the scene is Chris's reaction to the information he receives. As Jim explains the procedure, Chris gradually comes to understand the reality of his situation. What is particularly striking is that he moves from confusion and disbelief to a kind of resignation. Rather than responding with immediate panic, Chris appears to recognise the logic operating around him. This moment can be understood through the Afro-Pessimist argument that anti-Blackness is not an isolated phenomenon but an enduring feature of modern society (Poll, 2018:91). Chris's response suggests an awareness that what is happening to him extends beyond the actions of the Armitage family. The procedure may be fictional, but the power relations that underpin it are familiar. His resignation reflects the recognition that he is confronting a system that is larger than any individual person. Through Chris, the film captures the sense of vulnerability and uncertainty that Afro-Pessimism identifies as central to Black existence within an anti-Black world.

The theme of commodification is equally important within the scene. Throughout the film, Chris is repeatedly assessed in terms of what his body can offer. Earlier interactions with the party guests focus heavily on Black physicality, athleticism and appearance, reducing Blackness to a collection of desirable traits. The Coagula scene reveals the true purpose of this fascination. Chris is not valued as an individual with his own desires, experiences and identity. Instead, he is treated as a commodity whose body can be bought, sold and repurposed (Jenkins, 2024:48). This reflects a longer history in which Black bodies have been transformed into objects of economic and social value. The speculative horror of the scene therefore rests on a very real historical reality: the reduction of Black humanity to a resource that can be consumed by others.

This process reaches its most extreme expression through the idea of social death. Jim explains that Chris will not disappear entirely after the operation. Instead, he will remain conscious within the Sunken Place, watching his life unfold without the ability to control it. The significance of this

is that Chris is denied agency while continuing to exist. He becomes present but powerless. This closely resembles Afro-Pessimist discussions of social death, which describe a condition in which individuals are excluded from full participation in social life and stripped of meaningful autonomy (Poll, 2018:70). The horror of the Sunken Place is therefore not simply that Chris loses control of his body. It is that he remains aware of that loss. He can observe but cannot intervene, speak or act (Jenkins, 2024:51). Through this image, the film transforms an abstract theoretical concept into one of the most memorable visual metaphors in contemporary cinema (Poll, 2018:88).

The film's cinematography further reinforces these themes. As Jim reveals more information about the Coagula, the camera increasingly isolates Chris through close-up shots that emphasise his growing understanding of the situation. There are no dramatic action sequences or sudden jump scares. Instead, Peele relies on performance, framing and pacing to create tension. The absence of spectacle is significant because it allows the audience to focus on the social realities being exposed. Similarly, the visual representation of the Sunken Place emphasises distance, isolation and powerlessness. Suspended in darkness, Chris appears disconnected from both his body and the world around him (Jenkins, 2024:45). These images give visual form to concepts such as captivity, marginalisation and social death, demonstrating how film form itself contributes to the exploration of Afro-Pessimist ideas.

Taken together, these elements reveal why the Coagula explanation scene is the most significant sequence in the film for understanding the relationship between Afro-Pessimism and speculative fiction. Through the figure of Jim Hudson, Peele exposes the contradictions of colour-blind liberalism. Through the Coagula procedure, he reimagines historical forms of racial exploitation within a speculative framework. Through Chris's loss of agency and the symbolism of the Sunken Place, he illustrates Afro-Pessimist concerns about social death, captivity and the persistence of anti-Blackness. The scene therefore functions as more than a narrative revelation; it becomes the point at which the film's critique of contemporary racial structures is most clearly articulated.

Get Out uses horror not to imagine a monster that does not exist, but to reveal social realities that already do. By combining speculative fiction with Afro-Pessimist concerns, Jordan Peele constructs a narrative that exposes the persistence of anti-Blackness beneath the language of racial

progress and liberal tolerance. Through the speculative premise of consciousness transplantation, Peele transforms the historical logics of slavery and racial domination into a contemporary horror that feels both extraordinary and unsettlingly familiar. The film demonstrates how speculative fiction can be used to illuminate the structures that Afro-Pessimism identifies as foundational to modern society, revealing that the true horror of *Get Out* lies not in the impossibility of the Coagula, but in the recognisable realities that make it believable.

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